Introduction: Getting started

Learning Objectives

- Understand the scope and goals of the course
- Know the assessment format and grading criteria

Content

What is Pastafarianism?

The **Church of the Flying Spaghetti Monster (FSM)** was founded in 2005 by Bobby Henderson, a physics graduate from Oregon State University. Henderson's founding document was an open letter to the Kansas State Board of Education, which had recently voted to allow *intelligent design* alongside evolutionary theory in public school science classes. In the letter, Henderson demanded equal class time for his own supernatural creation theory: that the universe was created by an omnipotent deity made of spaghetti and meatballs (Cho 2023).

The letter went viral. In 2006, Henderson published *The Gospel of the Flying Spaghetti Monster*, which codified the movement's doctrine. Followers are known as **Pastafarians** — a portmanteau of *pasta* and *Rastafarianism*.

Core Tenets

Tenet	Content
Creator	The FSM created the universe "while quite drunk," touching the Earth with his noodly appendage
Scripture	*The Gospel of the Flying Spaghetti Monster* (Henderson, 2006)
History	The FSM deliberately hides evidence of creation to test the faith of believers
Holy figures	Pirates are the original Pastafarians; the decline of piracy causes global warming
Moral code	"The Eight I'd Really Rather You Didn'ts"
Afterlife	Heaven, which contains a beer volcano and a stripper factory
Ritual dress	A pasta colander worn on the head (used in official ID photos in several countries)

Origins and Context

Henderson's protest had an immediate effect: the Kansas Board reversed its ruling in 2006. The open letter, however, took on a life of its own. What began as targeted political argumentation became a movement with genuine adherents across multiple countries.

The question of whether those adherents hold their beliefs *sincerely* — and what follows from that — has become a live legal and philosophical issue. Courts in the United States, Germany, Austria, New Zealand, the Netherlands, and Italy have all considered Pastafarian claims (Palmisano and Ranzato 2025).

Henderson's Founding Argument

The logical structure of Henderson's letter can be formalised as a premise–conclusion structure:

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[Equal time]: The Flying Spaghetti Monster theory deserves equal time
              in public school science classes.
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<Equality argument>: Flying Spaghetti Monster theory deserves equal time
in public school science classes as the intelligent design theory.

(1) If one supernatural creation theory receives time in public school science classes,
    all other supernatural theories are equally entitled to time.
(2) Intelligent design is a supernatural creation theory that received time
    in Kansas public school science classes.
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(3) [Equal time]
```

> **Note**
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> **Note on premise (1):** Henderson treats this as a conditional applying to *any* supernatural theory. A natural objection is that premise (1) only holds if the theories are sufficiently similar in evidential status. This objection — and others — will be reconstructed in Session 2.

Exercises

1. **Identify the premises.** State the two premises of Henderson's equality argument in your own words. Are both plausible? Explain briefly.
2. **Challenge a premise.** Which premise is easier to attack? Formulate a one-sentence objection.
3. **Reconstruct in Argdown.** Using the Argdown notation from the session, reconstruct the following objection as a counter-argument to `[Equal time]`:

   > "Intelligent design is not a scientific theory at all. It makes no testable predictions and therefore has no place in a science class, regardless of how many other theories do or do not."

4. **Research question.** Find one example of a Pastafarian claiming a legal right (e.g. to wear a colander in an ID photo) in any country. Briefly describe the outcome.

References

Cho, Hyun Jai (violet). 2023. "Tax Exemptions, Spaghetti, and the Devil: The Perils of Ambiguous Limitations on Religion and a Proposed Definition for Legally Acknowledged Systems of Faith." *Przegląd Konstytucyjny*, no. 3: 61–82.

Palmisano, Stefania, and Jacopo Ranzato. 2025. "A Pastafarian Heart in a Catholic Body: The Italian Pastafarian Church as a Test for the 'Definitional Issues'." *Journal of Religion in Europe* 18 (3): 276–96. https://doi.org/10.1163/18748929-bja10120.